NORTHWESTERN POLYTECHNIC

DEPARTMENT OF FINE ARTS

COURSE OUTLINE — Winter 2026

AR2205: Art Since 1945 — 3 (3-0-0) 45hrs for 15 weeks

Northwestern Polytechnic acknowledges that our campuses are located on Treaty 8 territory, the ancestral and present-day home to many diverse First Nations, Metis, and Inuit people. We are grateful to work, live and learn on the traditional territory of Duncan's First Nation, Horse Lake First Nation and Sturgeon Lake Cree Nation, who are the original caretakers of this land.

We acknowledge the history of this land and we are thankful for the opportunity to walk together in friendship, where we will encourage and promote positive change for present and future generations.

INSTRUCTOR:	Kaveh Rafie	**PHONE:**	+1 780-539-2911
OFFICE:	online	**Email:**	krafie@nwpolytech.ca
OFFICE HOURS:	Wednesdays 2:30 PM – 3:30 PM or by appointment Zoom Link		

CALENDAR DESCRIPTION

This course examines post-1945 art movements, focusing on how rebellious and outsider art challenges and is absorbed by institutions. While centered on Western frameworks, it incorporates a global perspective, featuring both national and transnational artists. Students will analyze diverse media—including installation, painting, performance, photography, sculpture, and video—to develop a multifaceted understanding of contemporary art practice and theory.

PREREQUISITE(S)/COREQUISITE(S)

None

REQUIRED MATERIALS

No textbook is required. Readings will be provided on myClass.

Recommended:

- Sylvan Barnet, *A Short Guide to Writing about Art (ASGWA)* (available at the library on reserve)

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- Edward Lucie-Smith, *Movements in Art since 1945 (MAS)*

DELIVERY MODE

This course is delivered synchronously online via Zoom: Mondays Zoom Link | Friday Zoom Link

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- Analyze key art movements and their socio-political contexts from 1945 to the present.
- Critically evaluate the role of institutions and the market in shaping contemporary art practices.
- Interpret and discuss artworks across various media, including installation, performance, and digital art.
- Understand and articulate the trends and themes in global contemporary art.
- Develop skills and vocabulary for discussing and writing about contemporary art.

TRANSFERABILITY

Please consult the Alberta Transfer Guide for more information. You may check the transferability of this course at the Alberta Transfer Guide main page http://www.transferalberta.alberta.ca.

> ⚠ **Warning**
>
> For courses with alpha (letter) grading, a grade of **D** or **D+** may not be acceptable for transfer to other post-secondary institutions. **Students are cautioned that it is their responsibility to contact the receiving institutions to ensure transferability.**

EVALUATIONS

CLASS PARTICIPATION	20%
DISCUSSION BOARD	15%
QUIZZES	5%
FIELD REPORT	10%

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PRESENTATION	10%
FINAL PROJECT	40%

Class Participation

This class will be held synchronously online via Zoom. Active participation in Zoom sessions and activities is essential for a successful learning experience. Students are expected to engage with the material and contribute to discussions. Your grade is based on the following components:

Camera Policy

Turning your camera off will result in not receiving participation credit (10%) unless it is during a break or you have communicated with me in advance for accommodations.

Discussion Contribution

Actively contribute to class discussions by asking questions, responding to prompts, and engaging with your peers' ideas.

In-Class Activities

Complete all micro-activities, such as polls and short collaborative tasks, announced during the session.

Note on Recordings

Sessions will be recorded for educational purposes. By participating, you consent to being recorded. If you miss a session, please email me to receive the link to the missed session.

> ⚠ **Attendance Policy**
>
> Attendance for our live Zoom sessions is MANDATORY. You are allowed no more than TWO unexcused absences. Failure to address chronic absenteeism may result in failing the course.
>
> If social anxiety limits your participation, email krafie@nwpolytech.ca to discuss alternatives.

Discussion Board

Ask one question related to the week's lecture or weekly readings on myClass, and respond to at least two of your classmates' questions.

- To receive full credit, your question should be thoughtful and relevant to the week's material.

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- Short or superficial replies will not receive credit.

Quizzes

There will be periodic quizzes based on the readings and lectures. These quizzes are designed to assess your understanding of the course material and your active note-taking during lectures.

Field Report

This assignment assesses your ability to critically engage with contemporary art outside the classroom. You will attend a virtual or local art event (e.g., exhibition, artist talk, workshop) and write a 1000-word report analyzing the experience. More details will be provided in myClass.

Hint: For writing an exhibition review see Sylvan Barnet, "Writing a Review of an Exhibition" *ASGWA*, 1–34

Presentation

Students will deliver a 6-8 minute presentation on a selected contemporary artist or art movement. You can choose to present solo or partner up with a classmate. I always encourage collaboration so working in pairs is highly recommended and will be rewarded with extra marks (5%). The presentation should include visual aids (e.g., images of the works under discussion) and a brief Q&A session. A rubric will be provided in myClass.

Final Project

The Final Project is a research project on the topics covered in this course; you are encouraged to focus on a specific artist, art movement, or theme in contemporary art related to your own interests and practice. You are expected to develop your project in two stages:

Hint: For developing your topic see Sylvan Barnet, "Getting Ideas for Essays" in *ASGWA*, 75–130

Project Proposal (10%)

An approximately 250-word proposal outlining your research topic and objectives, along with a preliminary annotated bibliography. This proposal should demonstrate a clear working thesis and a plan for your research.

Final Essay Submission (30%)

A comprehensive research paper of approximately 1000–1250 words (or approximately 4 pages double-spaced). The essay should present a well-structured argument, supported by scholarly sources and critical analysis

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of relevant artworks. Proper citation and adherence to academic standards are required. Images of the artworks discussed should be included, along with proper captions.

Info

The writing assignments in the course require proper citation of sources. Please use Chicago style consistently throughout your work. Consult the Chicago Manual of Style or the Purdue OWL for guidance.

Late Assignments and Missed Exams

Assignments must be submitted by midnight on the due date. Late submissions receive a zero until accepted (at my discretion; I may not accept them). Submissions after the due date may be marked down by 20%, depending on circumstances. For emergencies or extenuating circumstances, contact me before the due date.

Warning

Please note that most universities will not accept your course for transfer credit **IF** your grade is **less than C-**.

GRADING CHART FOR COURSES WITH ALPHA GRADING

Alpha Grade	4-point Equivalent	Percentage Guideline	Alpha Grade	4-point Equivalent	Percentage Guideline
A+	4.0	95–100	C+	2.3	67–69
A	4.0	85–94	C	2.0	63–66
A-	3.7	80–84	C-	1.7	60–62
B+	3.3	77–79	D+	1.3	55–59
B	3.0	73–76	D	1.0	50–54
B-	2.7	70–72	F	0.0	0–49

- Grades for this course will be assigned as a percentage.

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COURSE SCHEDULE (WORKING)*

Week 1

Fri, Jan 09: Course Introduction and Overview

Introduction to the course and expectations. A walkthrough of the syllabus and assessment methods. A short introduction to writing about art.

Read:

- Sylvan Barnet, *ASGWA*, 1–36

Week 2

Mon, Jan 12: The First Half of 20th Century Art

A short survey of modernist movements of the early 20th century until the end of World War II.

Read:

- TJ Clark, "Introduction," in *Farewell to an Idea: Episodes from a History of Modernism*

Fri, Jan 16: High Modernism in New York

A short survey of Abstract Expressionism and its key figures in post-war New York during the Cold War.

Read:

- David Joselit, from *American Art Since 1945*

Week 3

Mon, Jan 19: What Comes After Abstract Expressionism?

A review of the characteristics and significance of Post-Painterly Abstraction in the evolution of abstract art.

Read:

- "Post-Painterly Abstraction" in **MAS**
- Sylvan Barnet, *ASGWA*, 42–48

Fri, Jan 23: European Post-War Art

Examination of key European art movements and figures in the post-war period.

Read:

- "The European Scene" in *MAS*
- Sylvan Barnet, *ASGWA*, 48–67*

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Week 4

Mon, Jan 26: Postwar Art in Africa

Examination of post-war art movements in Africa and their contributions to global art narratives.

Read:

- Chika Okeke, "Africa: Modern African Art"
- Sylvan Barnet, *ASGWA*, 69–74

Fri, Jan 30: Happenings and the Neo-Dada

Examination of Happenings as a precursor to performance art and their role in the development of Pop Art.

Read:

- "Pop, Environments and Happenings" in *MAS*, pp. 97–106
- "1955a" and "1961" in Art since 1900: Modernism, Antimodernism, Postmodernism (**ART1900**)

Week 5

Mon, Feb 02: Pop Art and Consumer Culture

Exploring art of consumer culture on steroids in the second half of the 20th century.

Read:

- Blake Stimson, from *Citizen Warhol*
- Lucie-Smith, from *MAS*, pp. 107–130 (optional)

Fri, Feb 06: Thing instead of Art Object

Exploration of Minimalism as a reaction against Abstract Expressionism and its emphasis on simplicity and objecthood.

Read:

- David Joselit, "Mimalism" in *American Art Since 1945*

Week 6

Mon, Feb 09: Art as Experience

Examination of the Fluxus movement and its impact on avant-garde art practices.

Read:

- Hannah Higgins, "Fluxus Experience"

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Fri, Feb 13: Earthwork
Examination of land art as a medium from minimalism.

Read:
- Suzanne Boettger, “Earthworks” (excerpt)

Week 7

Mon, Feb 16 – NO CLASS: Family Day

Fri, Feb 20 – NO CLASS: Winter Break

Week 8

Mon, Feb 23: Counter-Narratives of Abstraction
A critical examination of two parallel movements that emerged in the 1950s-60s to challenge dominant Euro-American modernist abstraction.

Read:
- “1959e” in *ART1900*, pp. 494–501
- Iftikhar Dadi, “Rethinking Calligraphic Abstraction,” in *Discrepant Abstraction*

Fri, Feb 27: Conceptual Art and Institutional Critique
Examination of the emergence of Conceptual Art and its critique of traditional art institutions and practices.

Read:
- Lucy Lippard, “Escape Attempts: Conceptual Art 1967-1972,” in *Reconstructing the Object of Art: 1965-1972*

Week 9

Mon, Mar 02: Video Art and Photography
Exploration of the use of video and photography as mediums.

Read:
- Jeff Wall, “Marks of Indifference”: Aspects of Photography in, or as, Conceptual Art (1995)

Fri, Mar 06: Bodies in Action
A focused exploration of the emergence and significance of performance art in the post-war period.

Read:
- Michael Archer, *Art Since 1960*, pp. 96–108

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Week 10

Mon, Mar 09: Feminist Art Movements
Exploration of the history of feminist art movements in the second half of the 20th century.

Read:
- "Feminist art movement". The Art Story Foundation.
- Amelia Jones from *Body Art* in *Art of the Twentieth Century (ATC)*

Fri, Mar 13: Culture Wars and Art in the Late 20th Century
Discussion on the intersection of art, politics, and society during the culture wars of the late 20th century. Act up and the AIDS crisis.

Read:
- Jonathan D. Katz, "'The Senators Were Revolted': Homophobia and the Culture Wars" in *A Companion to Contemporary Art Since 1945*

Week 11

Mon, Mar 16: Return to Painting
Examination of the resurgence of painting since the 1980s and its implications for contemporary art.

Read:
- "Neo-Expressionist tendencies" in *MAS*

Fri, Mar 20: What is Contemporary Art?
Read:
- Andrea Fraser, "The Field of Contemporary Art," in e-flux journal, Oct 2024.

Week 12

Mon, Mar 23: Biennials as New Spectacles
Analysis of the role of cities and biennials in shaping contemporary art practices and discourses.

Read:
- Charles Green and Anthony Gardner, "Introduction" in *Biennials, Triennials, and Documenta*

Fri, Mar 27: Collaborative Practices in Contemporary Art
Discussion on the role of collaboration in contemporary art practices.

Read:

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- Grant Kester, “Introduction” in *The One and the Many*

Week 13

Mon, Mar 30: Artist-Curator
Analysis of the increasing influence of curators in shaping art exhibitions and trends.

Read:
- David Blazer, *Curationism: How Curating Took Over the Art World and Everything Else* (excerpt)

Fri, Apr 03 – NO CLASS: Good Friday

Week 14

Mon, Apr 06: From digital to AI
Examination of the evolution of digital art practices leading to the emergence of AI in art creation.

Read:
- Annie Armstrong, “Forget Blue-Chip Art. It’s a ‘Red-Chip’ Art World Now” also listen to her interviwew on Art Edge
- Michael Wagner, “AI Slop Is the New Kitsch”

Listen:
- “The Rise of the Red-Chip Art World.” *The Art Angle*

Fri, Apr 10: Student Presentations
Student presentations on selected contemporary artists or art movements. See myClass for schedule.

Week 15

Mon, Apr 13: Student Presentations
Student presentations on selected contemporary artists or art movements. See myClass for schedule.

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STUDENT RESPONSIBILITIES

Online Communication & Professionalism: Students are expected to maintain a high-level of professionalism across all course-related communications. Please conduct your communications as you would any other professional experience. Treat your colleagues with respect! Join the lecture on time and remain for the duration of class and related activities. Students can expect to put in a minimum of 4 hours per week on out-of- class work. Assignments will be expected on the date required.

STATEMENT ON ACADEMIC MISCONDUCT

Academic Misconduct will not be tolerated. For a more precise definition of academic misconduct and its consequences, refer to the Student Rights and Responsibilities policy available at https://www.nwpolytech.ca/about/polytechnic-leadership/policies-directory.

**Note: all Academic and Administrative policies are available on the same page.

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION:

Plagiarism and the Use of LLMs or AI Tools

Submitting AI-generated content as your own work is plagiarism. This includes work produced entirely or partially by LLMs (Large Language Models) or other AI tools without proper attribution.

You must own your intellectual work. AI may assist with brainstorming, outlining, or refining language—but the ideas, analysis, and argument must be yours.

Permitted Use:

- Brainstorming ideas and exploring topics
- Creating outlines or structure for your writing
- Refining and improving your own writing (grammar, clarity, flow)
- Generating examples to understand concepts (not to submit)

Prohibited Use:

- Copy-pasting AI-generated text into assignments without substantial revision
- Having AI write essays, reports, or responses for you
- Using AI to generate analysis or arguments you claim as your own

Requirements:

- All AI use must be cited (tool name and date)

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- You are solely responsible for all submitted content
- AI errors, hallucinations, or misinformation will be treated as academic misconduct
- ⚠️ Copy-pasting AI-generated content may result in academic integrity charges and formal reporting

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